

Post-Industrial Imaginaries: Nature, Representation and Ruin in Detroit, Michigan

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Abstract

With plans underway for large-scale urban agriculture and a proliferation of representations made of the city's vacant lots, Detroit, Michigan is increasingly understood as a particularly hybrid metropolis that complicates conceptual divisions between city and nature. This article looks at representations of urban nature found in Detroit, focusing primarily on the work by photographers and journalists over the past 5 years as part of a broader discourse on Detroit's decline. By drawing from urban political ecology and critical work on nature, this article argues that representations of the city suggest an ambivalence, both popular and scholarly, about the emergent ecologies found in cities like Detroit. But, ultimately, journalists and commentators see nature in the city as a reflection of the city's absence, rather than its materiality, and so representations of Detroit reflect dominant conceptual divisions between the city and the non-human world. This article builds on work in urban political ecology and environmental history to argue that representations and discourses about nature are important in the production of just urban environments.

Introduction

In recent years, Detroit has become highly visible. In magazines, photography anthologies, blogs, art exhibits and online news sources, images of the city's decaying architecture have become popular and at times unavoidable. Once the providence of longstanding documentarians like Camilo José Vergara and Lowell Boileau (1997), images of Detroit's supposed ruins now leap up from magazine covers and allow photographers to ask weighty questions about material decay, temporality and romantic ruination. Through a set of similar aesthetic tropes — as well as specific architectural sites — photographers construct imaginative geographies (Said, 1979) of the city that focus on picturesque decay and a mournful longing for a Fordist past. These photographers highlight abandoned automobile plants, desolate streets, crumbling infrastructure and iconic ruins like Michigan Central Station and the Brewster-Douglass Housing Projects. And while there are certain positives to Detroit's increasing visibility, these images are deeply ambiguous and hard to place politically. They are gestures of

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compassion that nevertheless write urban residents out of the frame, and place Detroit in a mythic past rather than a vivid present. Residents and critics often refer to these images as 'ruin porn', a derisive label that demonstrates the extent to which these photographs are thought to be exploitative by Detroit residents and others who critically engage with them (Morton, 2009). As John Patrick Leary (2011) notes:

So much ruin photography and ruin film aestheticizes poverty without inquiring of its origins, dramatizes spaces but never seeks out the people that inhabit and transform them, and romanticizes isolated acts of resistance without acknowledging the massive political and social forces aligned against the real transformation, and not just stubborn survival, of the city.

Leary, alongside Jerry Herron and George Steinmetz, are representative of Michigan-based critics who neither downplay Detroit's present state nor celebrate its peculiar aesthetic.¹ Unlike many ruin photographers, who use Detroit as a muse for larger questions about myth, memory and natural reclamation, scholars like Herron and Leary connect Detroit's decline to issues of race, real estate, economic restructuring and the more mundane realities of racialized urban poverty.

In this article, I examine representations made of Detroit, Michigan, but focus on images that suggest Detroit is being reclaimed by the natural world. Images of Detroit's supposed reclamation at the hands of non-human nature — expressed by photographers, journalists, tourists, bloggers and amateur ruin enthusiasts — work to naturalize the processes that are presently constructing and deconstructing the city. These images help to obscure Detroit's present by pulling on conceptions of the natural world as culturally and materially oppositional to urbanism. Through recourse to a version of the non-human that reflects what William Cronon (1995) famously called the 'wilderness ethic', photographers and journalists reduce the complicated ecologies emerging in Detroit to a vague story of natural reclamation. Rather than help to construct an urban ecological imaginary that understands cities as diverse assemblages of human and non-human matter, images made of urban ecology in Detroit often use nature-society binaries as a way of furthering a conceptual displacement of nature from the city. By separating the category of nature from the category of city, photographers and journalists use ecological metaphors to effectively naturalize the social processes responsible for Detroit's decline. This does not just flatten the incredible complexity of the word 'nature' that Raymond Williams (1980) famously referred to, but also reduces the many human lives that constitute historical processes. Conceptual framings of nature have important implications for understanding cities.

Focusing on representations of Detroit is a way to grapple with Jerry Herron's (2007: 669) statement that '[Detroit] is the most representative American place on the planet'. But I am also interested in the political implications of photography in the broader construction of imaginative geographies. As Schwartz (1996) argues, photography plays a dramatic role in the construction and circulation of imaginings of the other through 'virtual witnessing'. Photographs of landscapes do not just reflect contemporary understandings of cities like Detroit but also work to create new urban ecological imaginaries (Gandy, 2006) with particular policy implications. Detroit residents are keenly aware of the ways in which the city is represented, and these images subsequently interact with the landscape in particular ways.

But this critique is only one part of the story. I also argue that images of Detroit's supposed reclamation at the hands of non-human nature suggest new ecological imaginaries that are being worked through by non-academic audiences. They represent efforts to grapple with the questions posed by Detroit's present state, and this hopefully suggests new understandings of urban metabolism that are in the making. This article is subsequently an attempt to both nuance the critical reading of 'ruin porn' by focusing on

1 For critical work on Detroit's ruin tourists, see Herron (1993; 2002; 2007), Sheridan (1999), McGraw (2007), Steinmetz (2008; 2009) and Leary (2011). For a more satirical take, see Morton (2009).

the ambivalence that is central to emergent Detroit imaginaries, as well as connect broader questions about urban nature found in geography and history to more popular or journalistic work. In the past three decades, geographers and environmental historians have become increasingly interested in what Bruce Braun (2005) has called a 'more-than-human' urban geography, an overarching term for a broad array of work that aims to integrate studies of the natural environment with those of the city. Through a diverse set of literatures and conceptual approaches — including actor network theory and urban political ecology — studies of urban nature have attempted to decouple Latour's (1993) 'modern constitution' (see Gandy, 2002; Swyngedouw, 2004; Kaika, 2005; Heynen *et al.*, 2006; Robbins, 2007; see Brosnan, 2004 and Rose, 2004 for overviews of urban nature from the perspective of urban environmental history). This article brings together insights from urban political ecology and visual culture in order to make an argument about the role of representations in the development of a 'more-than-human urban geography' (Braun, 2005).

In what follows, I begin by briefly analysing the general interest in Detroit's so-called ruins on the part of journalists and amateur photographers. These images draw on romanticized conceptions of material decay that work to naturalize the present-day city of Detroit and its residents. After analysing different categories of urban nature found in the city, I conclude by returning to the fundamental ambivalence of these images. Despite their problematic political work, these photographs are documents of ambiguity. Finding nature in the city — and understanding the presence of nature as an effect of urbanization itself and not just a counter — is a difficult undertaking (Kaika, 2005). These images and the responses to them make it clear that understandings of the socio-natural processes of urbanization and de-urbanization are challenging but also being worked through by popular audiences in potentially interesting ways.

The business of decay

Photographs of Detroit's decaying buildings and crumbling infrastructure have been a prominent part of representations made of the city over the past two decades, exemplified best by the work of photographer Camilo José Vergara as well as Lowell Boileau's project, *The Fabulous Ruins of Detroit*. Alongside Vergara and Boileau's longstanding engagements with Detroit's ruins, there has been an explosion of interest in the past 5 years that continues to grow. This includes image sets produced locally — *The Fabulous Ruins of Detroit* (Boileau, 1997) and *100 Abandoned Houses* (n.d.) are two such projects — as well as work produced by those from outside the city, like the 2011 work of French photographers Yves Marchand and Romain Meffre (Figure 1). Additionally, in the last 3 years, there were consecutive photo essays in *Time Magazine*, one 50-image series in *Life.com*, a photo essay put together by Witold Rybczynski on *Slate.com*, an early 2011 image set produced by *The Guardian* featuring photographs by Marchand and Meffre, at least two tour guides of the city's decaying beauty published online and in print and hundreds of Flickr pages, blogs, additional photo essays and online photography portfolios dedicated to Detroit's ruins (Design*Sponge, 2008; Hemmerle, 2008; Mahalak, 2009; Marchand and Meffre, 2009; Marlowe, 2010; Rybczynski, 2010; O'Hagan, 2011). In 2010, three collections of photographs were published and Johnny Knoxville, known for his role in the *Jackass!* movies, has even made a documentary about the city that was produced by a fashion company (Austin and Doerr, 2010; Moore, 2010; Palladium Boots, 2010; Marchand and Meffre, 2011). In 2011, there was a continuous rise in books and articles dedicated to the pros and cons of 'ruin porn' (Piiparinen, 2012). And while distinctions and nuances abound, all of these projects share an interest and passion for examining Detroit's crumbling infrastructure, overgrown houses and empty skyscrapers. Increasingly, image sets of Detroit are tied into the discursive scripting of Detroit as a blank state for artists and creative gentrifiers who want to tap into the city's history of art and working-class culture (See Ryzik, 2010).



Figure 1 Michigan Central Station (source: Yves Marchand and Romain Meffre, 2011; reproduced by permission)

The work of Sean Hemmerle, whose December 2008 photo essay in *Time* was entitled 'The Remains of Detroit', is particularly representative of recent images made of the city. In 11 photographs, he focuses on the two primary icons used to represent Detroit: cavernous empty auto plants and houses being overtaken by nature. Additionally, he features three shots of the iconic Michigan Central Station and perfectly explicates the tension between appreciation and repulsion that is so central to Detroit imaginaries. In a similar set of photographs published by *Time* in 2009, French photographers Yves Marchand and Romain Meffre highlight the William Livingstone Mansion, commonly referred to as 'slumpy' by ruin tourists before its eventual demolition in 2007. Additionally, Marchand and Meffre feature photographs of abandoned hotels and a decaying dentist's office, alongside a shot of the Michigan Central Station and some more photographs of abandoned automobile plants. More of these images can be found on their website (n.d.) and their 2011 book, *The Ruins of Detroit*.

Images of Detroit are not necessarily monolithic, and at times convey different impressions and responses. But the bulk of Detroit ruin photography feels repetitive, as photographers cover similar sites in similar ways. The particularity of this vision allows for photographers to construct an imaginative geography of the city that is focused on emptiness, ruin and picturesque decay. These images suggest a deep ambiguity, as commentators both mourn the city's current state while celebrating its picturesque aesthetic. As one journalist (O, 2010) for Seattle newspaper *The Stranger* noted:

The best part of living in Detroit is the ruins. The whole place is one giant urban-ruins park. Though it's sad and broken and abandoned, there is art everywhere. It's beautiful.

In these framings, Detroiters' homes and former workplaces are often seen as emblematic of the messy beauty of dereliction and material decay. By writing out residents from the story, catalogers of Detroit's decay effectively construct Detroit's decline in almost purely architectural terms.

Urban nature 1: pheasants

Photographer and sociologist Camilo José Vergara is arguably the scholarly forebear to Detroit's ruin tour industry. Vergara (1999: 16) has engaged in a decades-long investigation into America's declining inner cities that has yielded a series of books and articles that function as a way for Vergara to explore the 'soul' of neighborhoods amidst 'dereliction and destruction'. Instead of effacing the human presence from Detroit, as most catalogers of the city do, Vergara actually insists on including people in the frames. In his 1999 book, *American Ruins*, he notes, 'When taking a photograph I often wait for humans or animals to pass, giving a sense of scale and showing how they interact with the environment' (1999: 16). Vergara (1999: 3) himself defines his project as about social justice but also much more:

I also study the emergence of new styles; discuss the ways in which ghettos contribute to our national identity; urge the development of policies regarding the clearing, preservation, restoration, and stabilization of ruins; and try to foster awareness of the loss of so much first-rate architecture.

Towards these ends, Vergara (1997: 9) constructs a typology of American inner cities in which he does not demean residents' aspirations yet does critique their surroundings as examples of 'the exclusion of so many poor, minority people from mainstream society'. Some of his more striking photographs are products of his lengthy engagements with places like Detroit, in which he photographs one site over the course of years or even decades.

Yet there is a lurking romanticism and exoticism in Vergara's work that is troubling. Despite his concerns for social justice and his desire to humanize poor neighborhoods through the voices of residents, Vergara (1999: 23) is also drawn to the aesthetics of decay and he describes his initial forays into American cities as a product of wanting to engage with the realities of working-class urbanism in Gary, Indiana: 'With my eyes smarting from the smoke of the steel plants, I saw people gambling and drinking. I wanted to join them, but I felt alien and had little money; I could only look'. In sites like Gary, Vergara (1999: 23) found 'the challenge of [his] life', places where '[he] became so attached to derelict buildings that sadness came not from seeing them overgrown and deteriorating — this often rendered them more picturesque — but from their sudden and violent destruction'. And as he famously noted in 1996: 'In Detroit, decay renders even the most ordinary building picturesque' (1996: 16).

This tension in Vergara's work — between aestheticization and an active engagement with poverty and social justice — is one of the central ambivalences in Detroit imaginaries. Yet what is irksome about Vergara's project, and seemingly at odds with his own engagement with questions of justice, are the ultimate suggestions that he makes about what to do for the city. In one example, Vergara (1996: 58) suggests turning Detroit's icon of decay, the Michigan Central Station, into an abbey or monastery in order to dub Detroit the 'city where the Middle Ages work'. In another famous plan, Vergara argues that Detroit's pre-depression skyscraper core should be preserved as an 'urban monument valley', an American Acropolis where tourists gaze at the skyscrapers as they crumble.

His plan assumes a vision of urban ecology as a central component. He insists that for the American Acropolis plan to be successful:

Midwestern prairie should be allowed to invade from the north. Trees, vines, and wildflowers would grow on roofs and out of windows; wild animals, goats, squirrels, possums, bats, owls, ravens, snakes, insects, and perhaps even an occasional bear would live in the empty behemoths, adding their calls, hoots, and screeches to the smell of rotten leaves and animal droppings' (1997: 220).²

This plan was unsurprisingly not well-received. As one Detroit City employee pointedly asked me when discussing it, 'Who are we? The animals in the park?'³ And yet Vergara was shocked:

We may never see the buildings losing their stigma under the cover of nature: structures part man-made, part natural, their supporting frames exposed, their sides buckling, squirrels climbing up the vines. All I can do is to record the fading splendour of the buildings and the disjointed and anguished cries of those who try to make a home among them. Meanwhile, the wind moans through narrow canyons, and the near-empty People Mover creaks and curves along. There are stories of deer swimming from Belle Isle across the river to roam the empty streets among the skyscrapers. As officials plan to continue leveling, a space, able to restore our soul, waits to be discovered (Vergara, 1996).

As these quotes indicate, Vergara often uses natural metaphors and ecosystemic concepts to explain Detroit's ongoing decay. In this framing, nature in the city is a co-constructer of urban decline. But Vergara's conception of nature in the city is ambivalent — possibly a testament to the newness of the urban nature found in Detroit — and he often sees urban ecology as a vision of a utopian future as well as a dystopian present.⁴ Demonstrating this is the conclusion to his book, *The New American Ghetto* (1997: 214), in which he notes:

Upon leaving Detroit, tired and bewildered, I saw a large male pheasant fly low in an arc over the freeway, landing on the grounds of a semi-abandoned housing project. The energetic clapping of its wings, the rich browns of its plumage, its long tail passing so close to the dull cement of the highway — an unlikely phoenix.

Vergara is not the first to notice pheasants in the city nor is he the last, and pheasants in the city are actually something of a recurring trope, dating at least back to the mid-1980s if not earlier. Regardless, the extent to which Vergara understands the pheasants in utopian terms is telling. Against the uninhabited 'dull cement' of Detroit's decaying cityscape is a vision of nature as redeemer, an idea also suggested in many of his images. For Vergara, the return of nature to the city is a destructive process, as weeds and trees sprout from the roofs of buildings and cracks in the concrete, but this is a creative destruction that looks towards the future. By toggling between dystopia and utopia — the central axes around which representations of Detroit circulate, according to Sheridan (1999) — Vergara helps to elucidate many of the ambivalences that are so characteristic of the city. In one passage, he notes that weeds are sprouting in open spaces in Detroit, 'yet these are not wilderness retreats in the heart of the city' (Vergara, 1997: 16, cited in Gandy, 2006: 71). Vergara's comment gestures at the different natures produced in urban and rural contexts, even if decades of urban environmental scholarship has problematized the conceptual separation made between cities and natural environments (Williams, 1975; Cronon, 1991).

Urbanization is a socio-natural process but its results are uneven and often stripped of their connectivity, which makes claims to urban wildernesses seem counterintuitive. But urban weeds — even if they are not suggestive of the transcendent wilderness

2 The idea of bears in the city was recently expressed by a conservative commentator Steven Crowder (2009) in his diatribe against the Michigan Democratic Party. As of yet, there have been no sightings of bears in the city and it is unclear where Crowder heard about them.

3 Deborah Goldstein, interview by author, 5 August 2009, Detroit, MI.

4 For more on the tendency to see Detroit in either utopian or dystopian terms, see Sheridan (1999).

experiences commonly referenced in American environmental discourse — constitute a type of ‘social nature’ (Braun and Castree, 1998) with linked ecologies, discursive regimes and political possibilities (see Escobar, 1999). Despite their limitations, Vergara’s images suggest the particularities of post-industrial urban nature. While nature has always been in Detroit, there is something different about the socio-natural relationships currently being produced through Detroit’s decline. While assessing what is unique about the particularity of a post-industrial ‘regime of nature’ (Escobar, 1999) is outside of the scope of this article, Vergara deserves credit for elucidating the emergent ecologies in Detroit which differ from their predecessors. While he is still indebted to a language that separates out natural processes through concepts like wilderness, Vergara’s nuanced reading of Detroit’s ruins demonstrates some of the destabilizing possibilities of photography and representation more generally.

Other commentators are not so nuanced, however, and focus on crude binaries between urban hubris and natural reclamation. An online automobile magazine, *Jalopnik*, suggests this in an article titled ‘The Feral Factories of Detroit’ (Wojdyla, 2009). In it, the author notes:

it’s insidious, slow, unnoticed, but over time, the grasses grow tall, weeds fill in the cracks of once pristine and well-worn sidewalks, loading bays flood and become urban wetlands. . . . [Look at the images] to witness the astonishing power of nature to quickly return man-made structures to whence they came.

Julien Temple’s essay for *The Guardian* is perhaps the best version of this discourse, in which Detroit residents constitute ‘street zombies’ and the journalists ‘see full-grown trees sprouting from the tops of deserted skyscrapers’ (Temple, 2010, cited in Leary, 2011). An even more recent example can be found in a 31 January 2011 edition of *The Huffington Post*, in which Kiša Lala notes:

On the other hand who can complain when vast tracts of downtown Detroit are being reclaimed by nature. Like the ancient temples of Cambodia the earth always wins against the will of men. The city’s asphalt is cracking open and reverting back to prairie; foxes and deer are making malls and parking lots their new hunting grounds. The green invasion may enable a new vision for urban agriculture.

In these analyses, the abstraction of ‘nature’ is juxtaposed with the abstraction of ‘man’, resulting in a muddled account of Detroit’s decline that ignores the complex human and ecological dimensions (Cronon, 1991: 18). These representations of Detroit’s decline pull on organicist metaphors about urban change to naturalize Detroit’s present. This does not only simplify processes that are presently ongoing — and being contested — but also scripts nature as a distinctly feminine presence, against the agentic and masculinist will of ‘men’.

A more sensitive account of this antagonism between nature and the city can be found in Andrew Moore’s book of photographs entitled *Detroit Disassembled*. In it, Moore (2010: 119) rejects Vergara’s pheasants-as-phoenix idea. Instead, he argues:

Walking in Brush Park, a formerly grand nineteenth-century neighborhood, it’s not uncommon to disturb a pair of pheasants who’ve been enjoying having the entire city block to themselves. As they fly off, just above the fields of grass, only a distant row of partially rehabilitated mansions gives a clue to the urban setting. These days it’s not a phoenix arising from the ashes of Detroit, but two pheasants taking flight over weedy fields that mask piles of bricks and debris.

Although poor leadership on many levels has beset the city, the true engineer behind its disassembly is Janus-faced nature, which renews as it ravages this shadowed metropolis.

Moore’s photography at times suggests this opposition. In one of the concluding images in his book, entitled *Yard, Car Wash Café, East Jefferson Avenue*, Moore juxtaposes the



Figure 2 Detroit Dry Dock (source: Moore, 2010; © Andrew Moore, reproduced by permission)

residues of urbanity with what Georg Simmel (1959 [1911]: 260) called the ‘downward-dragging, corroding, crumbling power of nature’. In the image, two cars and an interstate sign lie next to a decaying house, but the real star of the photograph is the ivy that covers everything. Underneath a grey and foreboding sky, the fall colors of the expansive ivy suggest that nature is in fact winning.

Other photographs convey different moods, however, and suggest deeper connections between ecology and urbanism in the city. In one, Moore photographs a shelter built by a resident of a factory no longer in use (Figure 2). The shelter is composed of tarps, and the light shining through one of the tarps evokes a realistic waterfall. In another image, Moore photographs a carpet in an abandoned Ford plant. The image shows that the floor is being slowly covered by moss, but it is increasingly difficult to see when the carpet ends and the moss begins. In both of these images, nature is integrated into these sites in a way that raises questions about interrelationships and entanglements. Plastic waterfalls and moss carpets raise questions about where the natural ends and the unnatural begins.

Other writers and photographers are equally concerned with overlaps between natural systems and urban space in Detroit. Most prominent is the common idea of cities as organisms, an idea with a genealogy that is much too long for this article (See Gandy, 2005). Journalist Kristin Palm gives voice to a kind of popularized urban organicism in a 2002 article for *Metropolis*. She notes, in reference to the Michigan Central Station, arguably the icon of decaying Detroit:

How is it, then, that when we talk of progress in our cities we consistently fail to acknowledge the attendant concept of *progression*, an inherently organic act? No matter how much we

negotiate and finagle and brainstorm and build up, the truth of the matter is, a city is as natural as a forest or a desert or an ocean. Its structures will ebb and flow and cycle much as the trees and the sand and the waves will. And like any sacred spot in the Hiawatha or the Mojave or the Pacific, under just the right circumstances — say a mild midwinter day with late-afternoon sunlight turning the sandstone a gloriously warm gold — one empty building among them all might be the most perfect place on earth.

Recent dystopian tour guides published about Detroit echo this idea of the city's urban nature as a site for reflection and aesthetic appreciation. In one, a tour guide published in the *Chicago Reader*, the author argues (Mahalak, 2009):

A few hours' drive with no particular destination will take a visitor past not just overgrown mansions but abandoned skyscrapers, forgotten factories, burned-out bungalows, and swaths of wildflower-dappled urban prairie so large that you can forget you're in a major urban center. On the east side, whole neighborhoods already cleared by demolition and arson have been reclaimed by nature. Odd as it may sound, this is why you should visit Detroit now. If and when money ever comes in, you can be sure much of its eerie beauty will be lost forever.

All of these versions of urban nature articulate different visions of the non-human world and by extension ourselves, as Price (1999) argues. Despite their disagreements, these accounts still use non-human imagery as a way to naturalize Detroit's present state. Palm (2002) wants us to understand that cities themselves are natural and thus decay is at least partially inevitable, while Moore sees the particularity of Detroit as part of a broader story of humanity and the natural world locked in struggle. But there is a lack of precision in how these authors articulate what the natural world actually is. Most posit a version of the non-human that allows for popular understandings of nature to stand in as a partial explanation for what is happening in Detroit.

It is an inherently faulty metaphor. Using the concept of naturalness as a way of explaining Detroit's decline pulls on a particular construction of nature — as either destructive or redemptive, but always separate — to neutralize the processes that are presently constructing Detroit's landscape, most notably virulent racism and industrial restructuring. To subsume these processes in the comforting banality of abstracted nature is a way to, as Herron (2002: 35) notes, 'get over the responsibility of history'. One need only think about Alan Weisman's 2007 bestseller *The World Without Us* to understand the lure of a potential future in which the earth no longer has to deal with us.

These abstract imaginings of the city's disappearance ignore the fact that 'natural' is a culturally and historically specific idea. The manicured parks and tree-lined streets of Detroit's suburbs like Grosse Pointe are as natural as the weeds growing in the city's abandoned lots, but they suggest interrelations rather than crude opposition and pristine nature. Work in the broad (sub)discipline of urban political ecology has called attention to the diversity of urban environments and the degree to which urbanization is a socio-natural process. This scholarship has shed light on the political nature of urban environments by complicating conceptual binaries made between urban and natural environments. Yet by focusing on nature's capacity to counter human hubris, ruin photographers reject these overlaps in favor of a long tradition of American environmentalism that stretches back to Henry David Thoreau and John Muir. This is a genealogy that finds nature in the places where people are not. Nature in this particular conceptualization is understood to exist outside of the city, away from the moral dangers of urban space. This has the potential to ignore the degree to which biophysical processes and human intent or scientific knowledge are often co-constitutive. Understanding nature and the city as distinct conceptual categories renders them both opaque.

There is an obvious degree of temporal dislocation between post-Industrial Detroit and the late nineteenth century, but Keith Marlowe's 2010 image, 'Packard Plant: Landscape', makes the connections clearer. In it, Marlowe, whether consciously or not, suggests deep linkages between Detroit's ruins and Thomas Cole's *Course of Empire* Series, in particular the final image in the series entitled *Desolation*. Cole's famous

images from the 1830s — which depict the assumed consequences of moving away from a pastoral landscape — are hard to ignore when looking at images made of Detroit, as photographers and artists use similar aesthetic conventions in order to raise questions about the relationship between urbanism and nature. This assumes a normative ethical rejection of urban life that severs nature from the city and constructs Detroit's decline in moral rather than political-economic terms.

Ultimately, if we are to extend Palm's metaphor — that cities have natural life cycles — we have to think about what it means to suggest that cities are natural or unnatural (Harvey, 1996). Seeing nature as contingent and intertwined with urban space implies that Detroit is not so much returning to nature as it is constructing new urban spaces as it declines. This hurts the metaphorical potency of the natural reclamation idea, and makes clear that the city's decline is not necessarily inevitable, nor is its reclamation by nature. Understandings of nature's return to the city suggest that nature has not always been in the city, in the form of the raw materials used to construct automobiles or the vast infrastructural networks both above and below ground. With the exception of Vergara and possibly Moore, Detroit ruin photographers use nature as a way of justifying the city's present rather than constructing alternative futures. As Gandy (2002: 233) notes: 'The presence of nature in cities has served to naturalize the urban process in a variety of ways'. In Detroit, understandings of natural reclamation are one particular instance of this process.

Urban nature 2: feral Detroit

In an update to a 2009 blog entry entitled 'Feral Houses', which featured images of abandoned properties covered in ivy or blocked by the growth of trees, the author of the blog introduced the post by acknowledging that:

Nothing I have ever done has resonated as much as the photos of what I called 'feral houses' last summer. A quickly dashed-off blog post written while children tugged at my sleeves ended up capturing the attention of hundreds of thousands of people around the world and I still get hundreds of hits to that post every day.⁵

The post is indicative of the degree to which Detroit's ruination has stimulated interest, a point echoed by the profusion of ruin photography sets currently being produced. But the post, and the attached comments, also demonstrates the degree to which images of the city defy easy categorization. Critical work on photography has stressed the ways in which photographs are imbued with power through their occlusions and foci as well as their inculcation in broader regimes of power/knowledge (Fyfe and Law, 1988; Rose, 2003). But they are also open to interpretation on the part of audiences, many of whom invest them with different meanings or put them to use in different ways. The methodological technique of audiencing (Rose, 2003) suggests ways of getting past easy interpretations of visual images in favor of more nuanced understandings of the openness of visual culture within particular regimes of meaning. In the case of comments on blogs — a type of digital or virtual audiencing — the popularity referenced by the blog's creator demonstrates the degree to which these images are circulating within systems of meaning-making. One can see this in some of the comments, in which commentators connect these images to their own life experiences in the city or wrestle with the return of nature to the city.

A recent set of articles has called attention to this inherent openness of representation by arguing for more nuanced interpretations of 'ruin porn' as a type of landscape

5 Sweet Juniper Blog, 18 June 2010: URL <http://www.sweet-juniper.com/2010/06/more-feral-houses.html> (accessed 10 July 2010).

photography that calls attention to contemporary poverty (Christopher, 2012; Piiparinen, 2012). There is some significance to these arguments, and Piiparinen references the photography of Christian Burkert in his argument. Yet Burkert's photographs are unique, and he seems to purposefully play with many of the conventions of Detroit's ruin documentary industry. In the endless citationality that characterizes Detroit representations, Burkert highlights the central sites in the contemporary Detroit imaginary, including the Michigan Central Station parking lot, an overgrown house and the Packard Plant. Yet Burkert does one remarkable thing: he includes people in these canonical sites of urban abandonment. Alongside the continuously reproduced sites that characterize Detroit's virtual ruination tours, Burkert slyly intervenes. This is as much a response to 'ruin porn' as it is a response to Detroit's decline, and it demonstrates the degree to which urban representations are referential, at the level of reception as well as production.

Yet highlighting the stylistic diversity or openness found in Detroit's ruin documentation is a difficult undertaking given the degree to which images of the city are often identical, regardless of the photographer. One stylistic similarity that goes beyond choosing particular iconic sites and vistas is the degree to which images of the city efface the presence of Detroit residents. With the notable exception of Moore, Burkert and Vergara, most documenters of the city efface almost any human presence. The photography sets by Hemmerle and Rybczynski are completely devoid of human figures and in Marlowe's 52 photographs the most direct evidence that the city still has residents is found in one image that features bullet holes in the wall of a building. And if artists do happen to catch human life in the frame, it is often blocked out by weighty words about decay, collapse and failing empires. For example, in the *Time* photo series by Marchand and Meffre (2009), the editors of the series juxtapose an image with the following quote:

Ruins are the visible symbols and landmarks of our societies and their changes . . . the volatile result of the change of eras and the fall of empires. This fragility leads us to watch them one very last time: to be dismayed, or to admire, it makes us wonder about the permanence of things.

But the image appears to be of a footrace or political demonstration, and there is clear evidence of human life in the frame. Other evidence of people can be less direct. In many Detroit ruin images there are traces of people making use of these spaces in the form of graffiti and informal living quarters for the homeless or even, admittedly, Marlowe's bullet holes. Life even continues in the ruins in the form of entertainment: sites like the Michigan Central Station and the Packard Plant have long been locations for late night dance parties and the emergence of Detroit Techno.⁶ But actual residents — and not just their dystopian traces — are all missing from the city's visual representations. Even *Time*, in their somewhat optimistic piece on the city's future, uses a cover by Marchand and Meffre that features two people walking down an alley in the Packard Plant. Not only is the image deceptive due to the fact that it substitutes an alley inside an abandoned building for what appears to be a street, the cover also draws from what has become the standard color palette of Detroit images — muted grey — to convey the typically morose image of the city. And finally, and most disconcerting, are the human figures, dwarfed by the surrounding ruin and rendered into almost ghostly presences rather than actual people.⁷ This image, reproduced in Marchand and Meffre's 2011 book, *The Ruins of Detroit*, is one of two images in the book's nearly 230 pages that features recognizable people.

This blindness can be tied to the way in which nature, here understood through the lens of ruination, is central to narrations of Detroit's decline. Online comments on the previously mentioned blog post celebrate the return of nature to the city as a corrective

6 For more on 'Life in the Ruins' see McGraw (2007).

7 *Time*, 5 October 2009: URL <http://www.time.com/time/magazine/0,9263,7601091005,00.html> (accessed 27 November 2012).

for urban hubris. One notes: 'Beautiful. It's hard not to see this as some eternal struggle between humankind and nature . . . It's nice to see nature win — if just this once'. Another states: 'I am pulling for mother nature to take back that which was used & abused . . . consume it and keep marching forward'.⁸

As Kosek (2006) argues, ideas about nature are often articulated through hidden discourses of race and purity, allowing for nature to serve as a means by which racial categories are sedimented. The result is that struggles over wilderness are often struggles over purity and belonging, positing what Kosek (2004: 53) calls 'nature as always-already pure' against 'the ever-threatening elements which "have no right place in the landscape"'. While the nature found in Detroit is decidedly murky, one nevertheless glimpses in these comments a lurking desire for nature to reclaim the city from the impure human touch. Given Detroit's long and ugly history of racial antagonism and the fact that it is at present nearly 90% African-American, it is possible to see these comments as part of an attempted erasure of African-American Detroiters from the landscape. In the case of Detroit, residents of the city are written out of the scene, replaced by a concern for decaying architecture rather than the lives of those who inhabit these buildings.

In contrast to this writing out of Detroit citizens, Andrew Moore's images include residents in many of his shots, and he documents kids walking to school or hanging out in public. These give a sense of the banal and everyday that is often missing in images made of the city, and gesture at the 'inarticulate rich thereness of place' that Edward Said referred to (Said and Mohr, 1986: 28). In opposition to the colonizing gaze of ruin documenters — whose bird's eye views and cropped, decontextualized images suggest a city of architectural fragments — Moore at least gestures at the tactile geographies of the city, the 'pasts that others are not allowed to read' (de Certeau, 1984: 108). To see, and then to reproduce, is to help construct imaginative geographies that are then filled in by viewers and readers. As Greenblatt (1991: 122) argues, metonymy and imagination are crucial ways in which 'seeing turns into witnessing', a point echoed by Schwartz (1996). For Greenblatt, one can either probe for linkages and connections between ourselves and the other or else one can construct binaries and distinctions, paving the way for appropriation and re-scripting.

It is easy to tell the story of Detroit as one of disconnection and distance, and many have done precisely that. But there is another story that needs to be told about Detroit as well — a story about connectivity. Narratives of Detroit often stress the city's disconnection from mainstream societal values, as part of what sociologist Loïc Wacquant (1997: 342) calls the 'tendency to exoticize the [American] ghetto'. This tendency is part of what Jerry Herron (2010) is responding to when he asks, in reference to Detroit's standing as the most dangerous city in America:

Is this really a singular case — the case of a city committing cultural suicide or homicide? Or is it a case of something broader and more generally shared — a city being done in by the racialization of poverty and crime in America, with this place only making more visible things that exist — homicidally — across our culture?

Part of this involves starting to think about cities like Detroit as what Robinson (2006) calls 'ordinary cities'. Understanding Detroit as ordinary suggests that we begin to see Detroit's ongoing collapse — and not just its history — as part of processes that are still occurring. Rejecting metaphors of natural reclamation is one step towards seeing Detroit as an ongoing phenomenon rather than a finished product, as many of these representations imply.

But, in order to return to the inherent openness of visual representations, it is important to remember that these images and the responses to them are often too

8 Sweet Juniper blog, 18 June 2010: URL <http://www.sweet-juniper.com/2010/06/more-feral-houses.html> (accessed 10 July 2010).

fractured and inconsistent to suggest any coherent political or ethical position. In this way, they are demonstrations of a broad sense of ambivalence about cities like Detroit, and potentially gesture at popular reworkings of nature/culture binaries. Detroit is increasingly becoming known as a particularly hybrid metropolis, and artists working in the city have taken this up as a potent subject. One project, the Detroit Tree of Heaven Woodshop, was created in 2005 by German artists based in Detroit.⁹ The name is a reference to the famed *Ailanthus Altissima*, otherwise known as the Ghetto Palm, the Stink Tree, or the Tree of Heaven. *Ailanthus* is an aggressive invasive, capable of growing in sidewalk cracks and heavily disturbed soil, and it grows fast and reproduces faster. Over the past few years, the woodshop has used the tree as a way of calling into question the arbitrary divisions between urban and nature. They do this primarily by harvesting and curing the otherwise unusable wood, as well as a few comic installations: one that tries to farm these trees, and another that transplants them to Germany to be purposefully grown in temporary urban greenhouses. There is a lot of thick commentary imbedded in the project, and the idea of farming an invasive plant gestures provocatively at the limitations of conventional discourses about nature. Similarly, the work of Belgian artists Jef Geys, which tracks the presence of useful and medicinal weeds growing along Detroit's ceremonial Woodward Avenue, suggests deeper interrelations between the city and the non-human world. Karvonen (2011) tells a related story about the relationship between art, urban nature, and ecological subjectivity in his study of conflicts over water runoff in Seattle, Washington.

These projects point at some of the openness of the present. Despite the voyeuristic dimension that is implicit in many representations of Detroit, it seems fair to say that conceptual binaries between the urban and natural are increasingly blurry, both scholarly and popularly. In the case of Detroit, conceptual binaries are not necessarily working, so rather than see nature in Detroit as a potential way forward for an urban future, commentators are often forced to see nature in the city as oppositional. This has to do, in part, with an inability to understand the natural world as a place where people belong (Cronon, 1991). The result is that finding nature in Detroit is often a way to further ourselves from the natural systems we are invoking, as nature comes to function as a partner to popular dystopian imaginations. Anxieties about climate change and overpopulation seem to animate many of these ideas, which are subsequently integrated into classical tropes about the immorality of cities. Whether we are talking about weeds growing in empty lots or manicured parks in the Detroit suburbs, nature in the city is a filter for broader ideas about race and urbanism that serve to divide human and non-human systems despite their incredible spatial proximity. Much of this must have to do with the fact that the kinds of post-industrial urban ecologies seen in cities like Detroit have not yet been properly comprehended. Weeds growing in Detroit are as much a product of the city's materiality as they are a demonstration of the wild, yet they are often conceptualized as part of a return to nature rather than as part of a distinctly new and hybrid encounter. New urban ecological imaginaries demand new conceptual languages and ideas, ways of imagining cities that resist binaries and analytic closure in favor of an openness to the ways that ecology, community and justice intersect (Cronon, 1991; Gandy, 2006). This involves noting that the return of nature to the city is not as much a product of the city eroding as it is a product of the city itself. Detroit is a complicated city and there are no easy answers for the structural processes that are presently dismantling it. But calling attention to the ways in which Detroit residents are resisting the city's decline and imagining alternatives — while pushing back against overly optimistic imaginaries of the city's future — is one way to begin constructing new futures for the city.

9 Detroit Tree of Heaven Woodshop, URL <http://treeofheavenwoodshop.com/> (accessed May 2010).

Conclusions (urban nature 3: the coon man)

Glemie Dean Beasley, a retired truck driver, has recently become a minor celebrity in Detroit. Known simply as the 'coon man' due to the fact that he hunts and sells raccoons to eat, Beasley has played host to a series of reporters and journalists. His story is almost perfectly suited to a particular Detroit narrative, and he noted in an April news story: 'This city is going back to the wild. That's bad for people but that's good for me. I can catch wild rabbit and pheasant and coon in my backyard' (LeDuff, 2009). Like many Detroit discourses, the tale of the coon man has spread far, appearing in national newspapers and a host of blogs and websites. Barbara Ehrenreich used him as an example in a June 2009 editorial on the recession, and the writers for the New York Times' *Freakonomics* blog noted in August 2009 that 'Detroit is practically a giant food desert, with no produce-carrying grocery chains left and its citizens resorting to local raccoon and pheasant meat'. Beasley was even a participant in an NBC Dateline special on the city in April 2010 (NBC Dateline, 2010).

The story of Beasley is a fitting way to conclude this article. On the one hand, his tale is clearly representative of the citationality and reproducibility of imaginative geographies. The way in which his story has circulated demonstrates how quickly and easily narratives can be altered. The quick discursive shift from Beasley as one man to Detroit as a city where many live off raccoon and pheasant meat is the same kind of change that one can see in many stories about Detroit. It does not seem far-fetched to suggest that visitors to Detroit — or, more accurately, people who refuse to visit Detroit — will find their experiences altered by stories like that of the coon man.

And secondly, stories like Beasley's are fast becoming one of the common ways in which Detroit is understood as a kind of rural city, a place whose devastation is so thorough that it threatens to blur divisions between the natural and the urban. In a 2007 article, Rebecca Solnit gestures at some of these shifts. Her article predates much of the recent journalistic attention Detroit has received, and despite my distaste for the narratives that suggest the city is returning to nature, articles like Solnit's make it clear that something new is happening. As she herself admits: 'Having a city grow up around you is not an uncommon American experience, but having the countryside return is an eerier one' (Solnit, 2007: 72). For Solnit, Detroit's landscape is not yet post-apocalyptic but instead 'post-American', and her account of the city is warmer than most.

She retells the familiar story of pheasants in the city, but in the language of environmental history. For Vergara, these pheasants were a metaphor for redemption whereas photographer Andrew Moore saw them as a symbol of the eternal struggle between the works of people and the forces of nature. Solnit gives them a bit more nuance, and argues that the sight of two pheasants in the city 'was an improbable flight in many ways'. Solnit (2007: 73) continues:

Those pheasants, after all, were no more native to Detroit than are the trees of heaven growing in the skyscrapers downtown. And yet it is here, where European settlement began in the region, that we may be seeing the first signs of an unsettling of the very premises of colonial expansion, an unsettling that may bring a complex new human and natural ecology into being. This is the most extreme and long-term hope Detroit offers us: the hope that we can reclaim what we paved over and poisoned, that nature will not punish us, that it will welcome us home — not with the landscape that was here when we arrived, perhaps, but with land that is alive, lush, and varied all the same.

Solnit uses an understanding of the non-human as contingent and flexible in order to complicate Detroit's trajectory. Rather than reduce the story to easy tales of natural reclamation, Solnit admits that the nature emerging in Detroit is new and presents an ecology that is undeniably in the making. These forms of 'metropolitan nature', as Gandy (2002) refers to them, are an increasing component of cities like Detroit. They are a part of the story of the city, and they need to be complicated and deepened. While the insights of urban political ecology have demonstrated the degree to which urban sites are

assemblages of diverse processes and socio-natural flows, there is considerable work to be done to politicize these insights through an engagement with urban models of environmental activism, policymaking, and a renewed engagement with environmental justice. The need for urban models of environmental politics, which take seriously anti-essentialist, historicist understandings of natural processes, are of critical importance as we navigate just urban futures (Escobar, 1999; Swyngedouw, 2007). While recent efforts to bring nature back in the city have worked to destabilize longstanding binaries made between cities and their natural environments (See Karvonen, 2011; Kinder, 2011), there is more work to be done to ensure that environmental politics retain their critical orientation and embeddedness in broader structures of class and race. In the case of Detroit — where efforts are currently underway to seriously dismantle the city through the normative and managerial ideal of ‘right sizing’ — one has to wonder about the ways in which seemingly natural limits are being used to justify political interventions into cities. Urban interventions in the name of depoliticized nature can be exemplified by concerns over New Orleans’ potential rebuilding given its uneasy relationship with the Mississippi River or critical work on what scholars are calling ‘ecological gentrification’ (Dooling, 2009; see also Ghertner, 2011). These examples demonstrate that conflicts over representation and definition are about much more than Detroit’s future, but rather constitute an important space for critical interventions into urban policy and politics in wider contexts.

This article has argued that representation matters in the production of ‘survivable futures’ (Katz, 1995). Urban political ecology, with its focus on the myriad ways in which cities agglomerate flows and processes on registers ranging from the embodied to the macro-economic, needs to retain an interest in the work that discourse does in producing particular kinds of landscapes. The photographs addressed in this article are representative of a set of concerns about sustainability, poverty, race and economic restructuring. And while these images often do not suggest the types of answers this author is looking for, they nevertheless yield considerable insight into contemporary anxieties that reach far beyond Detroit. We need ways forward for constructing new models of urban ecological citizenship (Light, 2003) that privilege intersections and flows in the city rather than merely celebrate the return of nature to the city. The task is to find ways of imagining and representing the incredible complexity and relationality of both human and non-human systems, in order to better produce the types of socio-ecological futures we want to inhabit.

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Supporting information

Additional Supporting Information may be found in the online version of this article:

Figure S1 Yard, Car Wash Café, East Jefferson Avenue (*source*: Moore, 2010; © Andrew Moore, reproduced by permission)

Figure S2 View on Woodward Avenue, Broderick Tower (*source*: Yves Marchand and Romain Meffre, 2011; reproduced by permission)